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Dianne Reeves

Dianne Reeves is one of the most respected performing artists in music today. She was born in Detroit, Michigan, attended the University of Colorado and gained valuable experience with Clark Terry, Harry Belafonte and Sergio Mendez. Dianne has recorded steadily since 1982 and is well known for her original songs and for personalizing material from an eclectic mix of musical genres. Her most recent recording on Blue Note Records is "The Calling," a tribute to Sarah Vaughan.

Dianne was interviewed by Monk Rowe and Michael Woods following a performance at Hamilton College on October 13, 2001.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at the college, and I'm really thrilled to have Dianne Reeves with me this evening. And I have to try to find an adjective to describe your performance, but I just was thrilled with the amount of imagination that was going on on stage. Can you in any way tell me where that comes from?

DR: Well I think it comes from having a group of — standing inside of a group of musicians that become co-creators on stage, where it's a very intimate exchange that happens between everybody. Everybody kind of feeds off of one another and so it makes the music different from night to night on a certain level.

MR: Yeah. You had an interesting little story in your recent liner notes about learning a Sarah Vaughan note for note — and I mean that's an accomplishment in itself.

DR: Yes I think so.

MR: But your uncle said something about that?

DR: Yeah. Well he'd given me these records and the one that I heard first was with Michel Legrand and she was singing "What Are You Doing the Rest of Your Life." And it was amazing what she was doing with her voice. Her range was going through the harmonies and she was singing in a way that I didn't know that a song could be sung. And I fell in love with it. So I would play it over and over and over again and I learned it note for note. And then I had my instructor at the time for the big band do an arrangement for me of the song. And I felt really proud. You know I got up there and I sang the song exactly like she sang it. Well my uncle bought the music to the song, because I learned it off of the record, and he said, "This is how the actual melody goes, and just so you know, that's probably the way she sang it that time on that recording but after that it was different. She probably never sang it the same way twice, I can guarantee you." So it just kind of busted my bubble a little bit, you know. But it was from that point on I knew that you had to

have your own — I guess — concepts when you're dealing with music and songs. So I wanted to develop my own voice from that point on.

MR: Were there horn players that inspired you from an improvisation standpoint too?

DR: Well you know it's interesting because the one person that comes to mind is Cannonball Adderley. You know I had the opportunity to hear him when I was really young, and I just thought he was amazing. And I think that the thing that inspired me more than anything was that he had this way of creating places and times and pictures with an instrument that had no words, but he could make you have these thoughts and feelings about places that you've been or places that felt very, very familiar. He gave you pictures. So I think early on he was the one. And then I loved when he worked with Nancy Wilson. I thought that was really cool.

MR: Was that the best album ever made just about?

DR: Yeah that was a great album.

MR: Yeah, absolutely. And it's funny because she says that actually the critics gave her some heat about that, or maybe him.

DR: Oh critics give so much heat.

MR: Yeah. You know your repertoire is so broad based. Do you think critics have a hard time with that because they want to put you somewhere so they can talk better about it?

DR: Early on, when I was trying to find out who I was there was a lot of music that I was listening to at the time, and at the time fusion music was the music that was being played. That was the music that I was listening to. And I loved it because it encompassed so many things. It was for me like world music, without even knowing the term, because you'd hear people like Ravi Shankar and you'd hear all of these kind of exotic instruments and places, people from countries that you would not normally hear this music. Even Brazil was very exotic to me at the time. And the musicians had a great deal of respect for the master musicians from these different places. And I was listening to all of this, so I wanted that energy in my own music. So early on I tapped into that as well as the music that was very popular of the day, it was of course the Motown music. I liked a lot of that. I was listening to it and I wanted to do that as well. So when I started recording the critics would always say, "Oh she's just too broad." When they first started to hear me I was with people like Clark Terry and Louie Bellson and singing more traditional music. But when I did my first record they creamed me.

MR: How does it affect you? How did it affect you?

DR: It just made my skin really tough because there was something stronger than their words, and that was that I really was, in my heart I really felt that what I was doing was correct and that's what I followed.

MR: Yeah. Well if we were to look at your list of songs from this evening, you went from John Coltrane to singing that Leonard Cohen was it? But they all sound like they seemed to mesh together really well.

DR: It's all music to me. I've always believed that music should be without boundaries. And for me jazz, having a foundation in jazz music really kind of allowed me to be a part of different kinds of music, much like the musicians that were performing, or that created this fusion music. And I just felt that if you could take the popular tunes of the 40s and turn them into jazz standards then there was a possibility that with these new other forms of these other songs, or even songs that I write could even have a kind of jazz sensibility. So I wanted to sing the songs that really addressed my life early on, that really meant something deeply to me. And so that's how all of those kinds of songs came into being.

MR: Your last album with the Sarah Vaughan tribute, it must have been an amazing feeling to stand in front of that orchestra. It was done mostly all live, is that correct?

DR: Yeah. Live in four days.

MR: Wow.

DR: Yeah. It was amazing because, well first of all, and I have to brag, my cousin George Duke is an impeccable musician. He's someone that if he needed to conduct the orchestra he could have done that, if he needed to run the board recording equipment he could have done that. He was there and he really, really made sure that the sound, everything, the approach, the spirit in the room was right. We had these incredible string musicians there who didn't know what the project was about and one came to me and says, "You know this reminds me, we used to record for Sarah like this." And I was like, "Well this is dedicated to Sarah." So once they realized that it became a party. And those four days, they were not long enough, because we had such a good time.

MR: Impeccable arrangements. Really creative. You know people are always talking about trying to make the strings swing? Well someone did there.

DR: Billy Childs. I've known Billy for a long time. We started working together when we were about 19 years old and our relationship is very, very rich and musically we shared a lot of music together. So when this project came about I asked him would he do the arrangements and he's like yeah. So we would get together and have cappuccino and talk about the songs. Because it wasn't so much that I wanted to select the songs —she sang so many songs. Sarah sang so many songs. I wanted to really celebrate her artistry, her approach to the music. And so there had to be some certain things that were in the arrangements and I remember he was nervous when we first started and George told him, "Man you know her like you know the palm of your hand so do what you do." And it was great. And he wrote incredible arrangements.

MR: I'm curious, some of the really hip substitutions that were used on like "Lullaby of Birdland" and stuff, did you two sit down and maybe he would try things and say do you like this?

DR: Exactly. It was funny because I was touring a lot at the time that we were working on the music and — Billy understands a lot of times that when I'm singing certain things, certain harmonies, certain feelings that I want to project, the harmonies have a lot to do with that, with the poetry of the music I guess, with the lyrics of the music. So we'd sit down and we would talk about different things. I think the thing that we really worked very hard on was "Send In the Clowns." That was, because Sarah's version was just so spectacular, we knew that whatever was going to be done with that song had to be uniquely my own. And so we'd sit down and we would work on things and discuss the lyrics, discuss the mood, discuss the feeling, all of these things. And then he would write accordingly.

MR: Did you come from a musical family? I know, well, with your cousin, George Duke.

DR: Yeah. Basically yes. I have an uncle who played with the Colorado Symphony for over 40 years, and started actually with the San Francisco Symphony. And I had great aunts, two great aunts and a great uncle were musicians and they played the music of the early 1900s, so it was Bessie Smith, Ma Rainey, all of these more blues oriented music. And so that was like always in the house. That was very much a part of my growing up.

MR: Was there pretty much constant support when you decided that you were going to try to go into music as a career?

DR: Oh yeah. My mother, she didn't understand exactly what it was that I was going to do, or what I wanted to do, but my mother and father always made a way for me to do it. And my uncle was more my mentor early on than anything. So he was there.

MR: You had a fortuitous meeting with Clark Terry somewhere early on, didn't you?

DR: Yes. I met Clark — our jazz band won a city wide competition which allowed us to go to Chicago and perform for what was then called the National Association of Jazz Educators. And of course Clark has been affiliated with them for a long time. And he heard me and we started talking, and I didn't know who he was, I just knew he was this nice man. My uncle was, "That's Clark Terry" you know. And it's like okay. So when he would come to Denver, there was this jazz party that this man Dick Gibson would give, at the Broadmoor. And the first jazz party that I ever did was with Clark. And he surrounded me with all these great musicians. Once again I still didn't know who they were. My uncle would have to go back and give me records and say, "See this is this person, this is this person, that's who you were performing with." And sometimes it would be George Duvivier on bass or Major Holley, which was pretty amazing, or a lot

Rowles. It was pretty amazing. Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis. And I would come there with all my music together. My uncle would help me get it together, my keys, and tell them how I wanted to do these little head arrangements, because I was really into that and Clark just stayed in touch. And from that point on we just continued to work together and we still do.

MR: That's interesting you say that you had your keys together and your whole thing. Do vocalists ever — I'm not sure how to even ask this question—

DR: Just ask it.

MR: Do they ever feel pressured by instrumentalists to really, you know you better know your stuff here?

DR: Well I think my uncle just always wanted me to be prepared. I guess they do, but my uncle always wanted me to be ready and be prepared, be able to communicate clearly my ideas and specifically what it was that I wanted to hear or what I wanted. And so that was the training early on. And you know I would go and I would listen to other vocalists too. Because at the time there was not a lot of, there weren't a lot of schools for jazz, to study jazz music. So the way that you got it was through experience and through other musicians that would help you. At least that's how I got it. And I would go and hear other singers. Like for instance I would go and hear Carmen McRae and she was very, very open, so I could ask her a lot of different questions about how she was approaching songs, who did this arrangement, why did she do it this way or — and you know she would tell me. And I remember the first time I saw Betty Carter it was the first time I'd ever seen a vocalist really stand inside of a band and allow the musicians to be these co-creators and really, really use their own personalities as part of the sound in a band. And I wanted to know how do you communicate those things? How do you do that? And I had my own bands early on, and I think that the biggest thing that helped me was the experience and just continuously learning to be very, very clear and to be able to articulate.

MR: There's a certain amount of physicalization that you do. When I think back of when I saw Betty Carter, I can almost see a nice comparison there. Just, I don't know, the way you use your arms. It works.

DR: Oh, okay.

MR: I have a couple of little excerpts I'd like to play for you. And it's not a blindfold test, but— This is from your recent —

[audio interlude]

When you ask a horn player what he thinks about when he improvises, you might get a certain answer. Is there an answer from a vocalist that you think might be different?

DR: I don't know but I would say that when I have — it has a lot to do with what the song is about for me you know. I know when working with different musicians, I did an album called "The Grand Encounter." And I remember any time we did a song the musicians would always say, "Now what were the lyrics to this song?" They always wanted to know the lyrics to the song so that they could really, really tell the story in, I guess in a way without words. And that's basically kind of how I think when I'm, you know — "Lullaby of Birdland" is I think for me, more than anything it's nostalgia. Because when I first heard the song I remember where I was, who I was, how young I was and what an impact it made on me. And I think that when I'm singing I'm thinking about wow, I wish, if I were in that session how I would be, what I would do and I guess that's what that was.

MR: Do you find that you would change your choice of syllables and sounds depending on what kind of music you're scatting over.

DR: It really has a lot to do with placement of pitches and sound. I always look at improvisation, at least for me, as the words that you can't say, the things that come out of your soul. And any song that I sing I will change the sound or the timbre in my voice to fit what it is that I'm trying to say. So that probably is true with improvisation as well.

MR: It sounds like good advice for people trying to learn. You know there's an awful lot of method books out now, but did you ever have any of those at your disposal?

DR: Much later. Much later. But not early on. Not early on. And really a lot of everything came through experience. I remember when I had a band with Billy Childs and our music was just way out there. We would try to go as far out harmonically, we would perform on stage in a place where they didn't care about the music that we performed. It was a place for artists. So we were very, very fortunate to have that. And we would experiment every night. And I remember things got more and more complicated, more chance taking, and then I ended up with Harry Belafonte. And when I got with him I thought to myself, wow, I can't sing this music. It has like three chords and the melodies are real simple and you know I thought what is this? And at the time I was working with the great vocal coach Phil Moore. And he said, "I think that you should definitely do this, have this experience with him." And he was going to feature me. And what I found in performing with Harry Belafonte was that I had all of these songs that came from all over the world that had all of these dual meanings, you know some social, political meanings. And I found that there was a way that you had to sing them to communicate the message in the song. And that the harmonies were very, very rich and beautiful but simple. The rhythms were interesting and it was just different. And I found from that point on less is more. And so where in my early years when I would sing it was really, really about my

instrument. But later on, I think after my experience with Harry, it changed, and I wanted to be able to tell stories and use the colors that I gathered from the very beginning of my career to really, really color the words and to really make my point very clear with the lyrics and the stories that I was trying to tell.

MR: Great answer. You work with Sergio Mendes also?

DR: Um hum.

MR: Same kind of experience with him?

DR: Yeah, that was pretty amazing because while we performed the music of "Brazil '66," I have to say both Harry and Sergio really were into exposing you to writers that you wouldn't normally hear about. And when I was working with Sergio he would give me tapes and live performances of people that I had no idea who they were, people like Elis Regina or Maria Bethania or Caetano Veloso or all or these great writers and singers from Brazil. Ivan Lins, the first time I heard him was some songs that he had written that he sent to Sergio, he's like check this guy out. Beautiful songs. And of course I knew a little bit about Milton Nascimento but not as much as I did after working with Sergio. So there was a lot of behind the scenes things.

MR: I wanted to read something I recently read in a *Jazz Times* and see if you have a reaction to it or not. Angela Davis was participating in a conference about the basic question was is jazz colorblind. And she had stated she saw you on a concert with Jane Monheit and wondered why Jane Monheit had been on the cover of, I guess it was the *New York Times Magazine*, when you'd been around for ten, twelve years. Do you have any reaction to that?

DR: Well yes I do, and I think my reaction is more about the industry. Whether her picture was on the cover and mine wasn't, that is not, for me not an issue. But I think the issue is that you know when I think of someone like Sarah Vaughan who was 59 years old before she won a Grammy, and she had this extraordinary body of work that she performed with all of these people and was just this incredible artist who was not a star but an entire universe. I look at the industry and I think sometimes, well I draw strength from that. Because sometimes in the industry, here you have some young singers that are coming up and they say well they're the next Sarah and the next Ella and the next this, and that really, really is like fingernails on a chalkboard to me. Because when you think of people like Ella and Carmen and all of these great — Betty Carter, Abbey Lincoln, all of these great singers who have spent their lives developing their craft and really working at this music, you can not dismiss them. To me it's dismissing them by saying this person is the next. Because jazz is a music of maturity. And I think that in the industry, and it's not just in jazz music but it's all the way across the board, everybody is looking for that person

that young person because they never have the opportunity, really, to develop their own voice, their own divine uniqueness. And here you have them, you say this is what — they are like a blank piece of paper and there is some producer or something that wants to fill in the spaces and make them who they think that they should be. And I think as the listener, we lose out on something that could have been really beautiful and really unique. I have a lot of young vocalists that come to me all the time. Some of them have major recording deals who are really fighting for their own voices. They say, "You know they want me to do this and I'm not feeling this and how do I do this?" I think that if I had to record now in this industry I would probably go crazy because of the controls that are on these young lions that come in. But there are some that are coming through and they are fighting for their own voices, their own sound, their own concept, their own way that they view the music and I think that the broad listening audience needs that. Because there is such a sameness in the music and that goes even in jazz music. I have young musicians that come to me you know, "I want to do this but I need a hook for the publicist to use me." And it's like no, you need your own voice, you need to really fight for your own voice. Because that's what's the most important thing. And so I think more than anything I think that the industry really gets in the way of the growth of the organic, beautiful, unique qualities that somebody might have.

MR: Yeah. It's almost like what nerve to say someone is the next Ella after one album.

DR: Yeah you can't. Or even to — I know one thing, when I was doing this Sarah Vaughan record I just really wanted people to know that I was not trying to do a commentary on Sarah. And that's what happens. And I won't let anyone say that I'm the next, I just want to be Dianne Reeves. And that's what I stress with a lot of young people that come. It's like you must stress, in the very beginning, that you want to be your own self. Because that's what is needed. And I find that I guess it's easier for the people who write the articles to say that but to me it's not a well thought out statement.

MR: You have a pretty good relationship with Blue Note?

DR: Yeah. I have to say one thing about Blue Note is they do allow their artists total artistic freedom which is really great.

MR: That's good. I have one more little piece of music that I'd like to play for you. It's been a favorite of mine and I think it was a favorite of yours.

[audio interlude]

I was impressed by what you were playing between your breaks too. What led you to this?

DR: Well see it's about a country preacher and when you listen to the way that he is playing, and when you listen to the song, you feel all of those things. And that's why I wrote the

MR: This part kills me here.

DR: Yeah.

MR: I wish I had been there for that moment. It's just unbelievable.

DR: Yeah.

MR: Interesting that George Duke ended up with Cannonball too.

DR: Yes.

MR: You guys had a mutual —

DR: Actually I saw him with Cannon.

MR: Yeah?

DR: Yeah. It was like wow, this is incredible. The other thing I liked is when he was on stage he really let the audience know what they were going to do, what the music was about, so you felt you had an education. You were waiting for certain thing to happen because he said that this is what this song is about and this is, you know, he kind of educated his audience, which I loved.

MR: Well this has been really fascinating to talk to you. I'm going to invite my colleague Michael Woods in for a few questions if you don't mind.

DR: Okay.

MR: And we'll see you in a bit.

DR: Thank you.

MR: It's not really fair tag-teaming somebody, is it?

DR: I know. I'm in the hot seat.

MW: Your concert tonight I thought was absolutely fabulous.

DR: Thank you.

MW: From many, many standpoints. From the variety of the songs that you sang and from the energy level that each song reached, which I thought was scintillating. I wanted to ask you where or how did you come by such conceptual strength?

DR: Well without even going into great detail, the music saved my life. And I know growing up the music that I would listen to was really a backdrop for the Civil Rights movement, for the Vietnam War, the music was full of hope and brotherhood and positivity on all levels, not just songs that had political or social meanings but also about how men felt about women, vice versa, all of it was very, very beautiful. And I needed to hear all of those things. For me I think performance is more like meditation than it is giving a performance. It's a spiritual place for me. So I just want to make sure a lot of times that the words that I sing about or the things that I sing about are things that I really, really believe in my soul that are really, really a part of who I am. And I think a lot of that is really what kind of shapes the music, the concept, my approach.

MW: Let me ask you this. The songs that you sang tonight, all of them were profound. They were gripping. Much of the music that I hear in the pop world today is so surface. And even if it were to be sung well it wouldn't mean much because the lyrics don't take me anywhere. What in a set of lyrics attracts you to say yes I'd like to sing that song?

DR: I like lyrics that tell a story, that have very, very, that really, really kind of most of the songs really address my own life, things that I really think about, that I think that I can give my own emotion and understanding to, so that the audience understands it more the way that I'm hearing it, more than maybe the way the person wrote it. Also I think just, it really all comes down to just really feeling very humble, to be able to have the opportunity to do what it is that I do. I think that's the greatest thing.

MW: That's fantastic that you would say that because I've always thought there's tremendous spiritual connections between what a person performs and what they actually think and live out and do. It gives your music this elusive quality we call authenticity. I want to ask you about one of your incredible skills, and that is when you're singing a lyric and when you're scat singing, you seem to be able to go back and forth between the coloration of the word and between the scat symbol with such unbelievable ease. When did know you had such a skill? How do you practice something that is that spontaneous and that creative? How do you perfect that?

DR: Wow I've never been asked that. I really think that it goes back to just the experience of having — being in these different settings with different bands and musicians that are really great at what they do, and always feeling more comfortable being hungry. I always feel comfortable being hungry. So I put myself in positions that are, I don't know, kind of scary, that make you dig really deep and find things. And I believe that for me improvisation is my soul utterance. So whatever I'm singing in the lyrics, whatever I improvise, they're kind of one and the same. And I think just throughout the years of constantly doing this, early on I remember the longest time on stage for me was between songs. Because I didn't know how to speak to an audience. And I didn't want to just like introduce the next song, but I needed something to do between the songs so that I just didn't feel like I was naked in front of the audience. So what happened was these vamps on the ends of songs. And from that came the storytelling. And I think that's where all the — my way of improvising came into being — telling stories. I could sing it but I couldn't say it so I would always sing over the top of it so it kind of came from, like I said, experience, purely experience. Having the opportunity night after night, going out there and finding something in myself that I didn't know existed.

MW: You say you could sing it but you couldn't say it.

DR: Yeah. I can say it now but then I couldn't.

MW: That's so fantastic because there's so many people who would like to sing and they think and they feel the things that you feel but they couldn't find the notes to sing it with so I think you give them that outlet. Like when I see Michael Jordan I realize I can't jump over the Sunday sports page. I want to ask you, there's a word that I heard you use several times tonight, which I think is a fantastic word, and I don't hear that many vocalists use that word. And I would like to know what your sense of musicianship is tied to that word. You used the word sensibility. Fantastic word.

DR: Well I feel that I come from a place, a foundation that allows for the celebration of uniqueness. That's how I view jazz music. And through that I am able to take the kinds of songs, lyrics, ideas and give them that kind of freedom, free sensibility, the ability the change from night to night and that's what I love. Because to me that's what life is. And I think jazz is life. I equate jazz with life and life experience. And so I guess that's what I mean when I say that. I need to be able to take the music and breathe life in it, just like I learned. Just like when I listen to — any time I put on a great jazz musician or a great jazz vocalist, there's life in the music. How do you make that? How do you draw a picture and make it have dimension? And I think that's — you look at it, you see how, for me I see how it addresses my life and sometimes there are songs that don't necessarily address my life but they are places that I need to get to. And I believe that there is power in words, and so that's why I select them to sing because I'm trying to get to that place.

MW: You told us about stories. You sang the song for us "When You Were Nine Years Old." That song just transported me. I thought I was going to come out of my chair. Because it was so vivid. It was so descriptive and beautiful and alive. Tell us a story that you haven't put to melody yet.

DR: Well—

MW: Let's say it's 2004 and you've traveled all over the world and sung all different kind of places, and you're going to an album and you're going to tell us another story. Tell us about this one. Just take me there in your imagination.

DR: Well I think that the first word that comes to my mind is grace. I think the story would be about maybe where I am right now, how I feel and how I view life right now. Because there are a lot of things that are happening, like I've given my life to music. I've created a kind of imbalance in my life because I haven't really given much to my personal life. Now I need to know what that's about, and I want to write about that journey of finding that balance. And grace has a lot to do with that. Living in a state of grace.

MW: I'll ask you one more question.

DR: I've never had anybody ask me that but that's a good one.

MW: I go some strange places too.

MW: And I try to get creative in the classroom and probably we will wind up showing this video in my classroom. As a matter of fact several of my students were there to see you tonight and I played for them, to their sensibilities, in order to know how to appreciate your skill level, I played for them "Fascinating Rhythm." I played "Send In the Clowns," and I played "Lullaby of Birdland." And so they kind of had some idea of what to expect. But if you could sing anytime, anyplace, about any subject, and you knew that the power of your voice would change, improve, enhance, inspire the sonic landscape, and anybody within the throw of your voice, how would you sing to America after September 11th?

DR: I guess the way that I am now, from my heart. The interesting thing about what happened September 11th is it brought about, God, a profound sense of fear that I don't think that I've ever felt before. But also it made me think about some of the stories that my grandmother used to tell me of the things that she went through. And I heard the stories but I didn't feel that kind of fear. Didn't know what she'd been through, being like just a couple of steps out of slavery. And one of the things that came out of it was forward thinking perseverance, and now allowing the fear to take you down. So in answer to your question I think I would just continue to sing songs about strength and forward movement and try to stay aware and clear and present. Because there are so many things right now that are happening that can seduce you into feeling like maybe — not that it's worse than what it is, but losing your, I don't know, your things that you believe in. Breaking down your belief systems. And you can't let it do that. So I will continue to sing the kinds of songs the kinds of music that I've always sung, the kind of music that's always gotten me through, and the kind of music that really has gotten me through this time.

MW: Gotta make it through the night.

DR: Yes, absolutely.

MW: Well listen I just want to, first of all I want to tell you I think you're more than a great vocalist.

DR: Thank you.

MW: I think that your gift, the voice that you have, is a gift to people all over the world. Not that many people on this planet that will ever live and breathe on this planet will be able to sing like you do.

DR: Thank you.

MW: And I want to thank you immeasurably for bringing that skill to Hamilton College.

DR: Thank you very much.

MW: Thank you.